



PRACHANDA (LEFT) AND
REINSTATED ARMY CHIEF
KATAWAL



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chy. External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee was quick to speak about the crisis in Nepal, in the midst of campaigning. "What is happening in Nepal is internal to Nepal. We wish Nepal well in its transition to a fully democratic polity and would hope that the present crisis is resolved in a manner which contributes to the early conclusion of the peace process," he declared, in a bid to divert accusations of Indian involvement in the crisis in Kathmandu.

The challenge for New Delhi is to avoid any overt diplomatic action but at the same time prevent increased Chinese influence over Nepal. And that will be a tough call. India seems to have mismanaged its Nepal policy. In 2008, even at the cost of its traditional alliance with the mainstream political parties the Nepali Congress (NC) and the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist), CPN-UML, New Delhi decided to support a Maoist government in Kathmandu, in the hope that it would provide a semblance of order.

STATE OF TURMOIL

June 2001: King Birendra, Queen Aishwarya and other close relatives killed in a shooting spree by Crown Prince Dipendra, who then shoots himself. Gyanendra is crowned Nepal King.

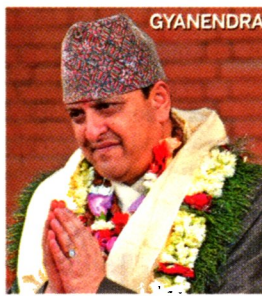
May 2002: Parliament dissolved and fresh elections are called over extending emergency. Sher Bahadur Deuba heads interim government and renews emergency.

April 2006: The King agrees to reinstate Parliament following protests. G.P. Koirala appointed prime minister. Maoists declare a ceasefire.

May 2006: Parliament curtails the King's powers. Government and Maoists begin talks.

November 2006: Maoists and the government sign accord and declare a formal end to a 10-year insurgency.

January 2007: Maoist leaders enter Parliament under a temporary constitution.



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December 2007: Parliament approves abolition of monarchy as part of peace deal with Maoists.

April 2008: Maoists win the largest number of seats in the new Constituent Assembly.

May 2008: Nepal becomes a republic.

August 2008: Prachanda forms coalition government and the Nepali Congress becomes the Opposition.

May 2009: Prachanda resigns citing the "un-constitutional and undemocratic" move by the President to stop the government from sacking the army chief.